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Postmodernity and new monumentality

GIANNI VATTIMO

1. The monument revisited

A number of contemporary voices in aesthetics, art criticism, and architecture seem to concur, despite their differences, in acknowledging a newly found legitimacy to monuments, perhaps even a renewed demand for them. The now-popular appeal to “save” the historical districts of our cities, and generally to protect and turn to better account the artistic and cultural patrimony often associated with the appeal to the protection of the environment, is one side of the issue. The “environment” itself, by which we mean nature—air, water, forests, and so on—is perhaps less a matter of “nature” than a matter of history. In fact, the issue is not merely to ensure life’s endurance for its own sake: in all likelihood, some form of life capable of surviving under the new conditions produced by air- and water-pollution could still be found. What we would like to preserve are not simply the conditions of life in general but of this particular life, the one in which we find ourselves to be living, qualified by its own particular history.

That certain basic conditions of life look more like nature than like culture to us simply means that they point to a more remote history, one that is so ancient as to look non-historical. Various influential movements aiming at the rationalization of architecture in the name of genuine human needs, of pure function, or of similar ideals, have often thought they could take “nature” as their standard reference. But such a reference was in turn determined by a historical condition: it was a cultural mythology symmetrically juxtaposed to another, equally cultural stance, one valuing instead that which is artificial, decorative, and superfluous. It would be a mistake to resolve the opposition between the call to nature and the loyalty to history into an ever-recurring dialectical polarization; it would be tantamount to opting surreptitiously for a naturalistic attitude, whereby the combined action of two “drives”—to nature and to history respectively—rhythmically alternating with one another, is seen as the permanent, and ultimate, natural structure. The opposite, rather, is true. Every dwelling begins with a separation from nature, and therefore constitutes itself as radically historical. (Incidentally, my claim is that “true” here does not refer to some essential structure to be grasped but is instead to be thought of

in historical, “destinal” terms, in a sense that shall become clear.) The actual need for a renewed “natural” foundation that is keenly felt in certain ages is a deeply cultivated, artificial, and historical one; this is also the case for the call to nature rising from contemporary ecological movements. They seem to reproduce the same paradox that Karl Löwith, thinking of Nietzsche but also revisiting a characteristically romantic motif, saw at work in modernity: the striving to reconstruct a “natural,” cyclic temporality as the endpoint of a linear process of development that is historical in the strong sense of the term. Man’s dwelling is not inspired or sustained by two equally original, dialectically juxtaposed sources that, at regular intervals, prevail on one another. There is, instead, “occurrence,” the constituting of openings of Being, which manifests itself as historicity of dwelling, as the need for a kind of legitimation that takes its distance from, and locates itself vis-à-vis an origin, in turn historical and eventual. Dwelling must locate itself within a space that is legitimized, marked, measured by ground-laying events. That such events are sometimes conceived as identical with nature only means that they are thought of as remote history, one that is more ancient and more “true” than any history; yet, by their being events, they are essentially historical themselves.

The widely debated issue concerning the preservation of historical districts and of the artistic and cultural patrimony is, therefore, not to be approached in ecological terms—namely, in the sense of a more “natural,” more authentic relation with the environment. Instead, the opposite is true: nature itself poses an issue, for it too appears under a different light as it becomes increasingly evident that man’s existence is essentially historical and eventual. The need for monuments, one might summarize, is more ancient than the need for a “natural environment”; better still, the latter is only a metaphorical mode of the former.

The link that ordinary language suggests, between cultural patrimony, monuments, cities, on the one hand, and environment and nature, on the other, may provide us, I believe, with an interesting clue for approaching the question of monument. Not simply because, as it is often said, the monument presents itself as a kind of “second nature”; but mainly because nature (rather, the longing for nature) only becomes an issue in an age and a society that are deeply marked

by history and historical consciousness. The romantic longing for nature is not just a remnant of previous eras in the age of history; on the contrary, it is an essential, characteristic feature of that very age.

The cult of artistic genius, born in Europe well before the eighteenth century, is rooted in sixteenth-century humanistic culture. It is the cult of a faculty capable of instituting a legislation that is absolutely original, therefore historical, and endowed with a "natural" legitimacy. For reasons not too difficult to determine, genius has a bearing on monument. Genius, we might say, is the faculty to create monuments, to found works that, one thinks, are imbued from the beginning of a monument-like quality, a founding power, rather than merely receiving it from the course of history, from their reception, and from the sense that is attributed to them (even Valéry's phrase, "*mes vers ont le sens qu'on leur prête*" ["my lines have the sense that one is borrowing them"], is probably not to be understood as hermeneutic nihilism but as the recognition of the radically eventual character of monument, of the artwork; Valéry is perhaps closer to an hermeneutic ontology than it is generally acknowledged). In the cult of genius modern conscience attempts to solve the problem of bestowing upon the newborn work of art that remoteness that alone can endow it, or so it seems, with its aesthetic quality; the nature-inspired genius, who creates without being able to say how and why, is the medium of such remoteness. The "natural" root of his work merely guarantees its value, by referring to an origin that is remote, although not chronologically so. Indeed, something of the genius cult still survives today in fashion, both in housing and clothing. The house designed by the renowned architect is a surrogate of the old family house, rich in memories, and, therefore, legitimacy. Similarly, fashion designer clothes do not just answer the obvious need for "distinction" amidst the plethora of mass-produced goods. Rather, that very need is rooted in a need for historicity, that is, in a need for identification and legitimation; ultimately, a need for monument. What the search for signature-bearing artifacts attests to is not the will to prevail over the others in the game-of-life struggle by distinguishing oneself and outdoing the opponents according to the logic of status symbols; more radically, it is the ever-renewed need for a way out of the natural world of struggle for survival, and for a historical, eventual foundation that places one in the world of culture.

To put it otherwise, what I am trying to approximate is a description, as well as an explanation, of something that looks like a "rediscovery" of monument in our culture (a hypothesis in itself still subject to discussion). This does not necessarily mean, however, that the conditions for a new culture of monument actually hold; on the contrary, it may be, as a number of signs indeed suggest, that the rediscovery of monument manifests a demand that is felt precisely insofar as it remains unanswered. It may be, for instance, the manifestation of a need for a slower pace in an age of dizzy accelerations; a need for memory in a largely amnesiac age.

I should probably acknowledge a certain degree of ambiguity in what I have indicated as the rediscovery of monument, or monumentality. Such ambiguity becomes all the more explicit when looking for supporting evidence in contemporary society. The rapid acceleration of technological development under the lead of science is one of the essential features of our civilization, threatened by the danger of amnesia. Yet it is seemingly paradoxical that it is that very acceleration that produces new monuments: cities are disseminated with dismissed industrial areas, which, once their productive function is lost, take on the quality of sheer traces and end up "imposing" their own presence on the city, any contrary resolution notwithstanding. They somehow resist being liquidated with a clean, rational gesture, which both economic considerations and aesthetic evaluations would dictate. An old factory should be demolished in order to create new and often much needed building areas; there are no reasons to preserve it, in most cases, on the basis of a rigorous aesthetic evaluation, since old factories are usually "ugly" artifacts. Yet what exactly is a rigorous aesthetic evaluation? Industrial archaeology, as well as the policy of including in the "artistic patrimony" also decidedly ugly buildings, unveil another side to the question of the monument. They may force us to confront the fact that aesthetic value, which sometimes is believed to be grounded in specific and clearly defined standards (such as form, self-sufficiency, exemplariness within a given domain, proportionate arrangement of the work's elements, and so forth) is largely, or perhaps entirely, a matter of traces and memory. It may well be that in the end what is termed as beautiful is simply what is "historical" in a pregnant sense: monument, that is. (Natural beauty would fit perfectly in this perspective, as the monument of a still remoter past.) But is the

proliferation of traces, in which we are confronted by the acceleration of productive processes insofar as they leave behind more and more “documents” and residues, also a proliferation of monuments? Or at least, does it specifically qualify our culture as a culture of memory? For instance, may we consider essential and decisive the discovery, if it is such, that what we believed to be aesthetic value is nothing but, or not much more than, *trace*?

2. Truth-as-monument

If we leave aside sociological observation—as suggestive in its intellectual stimulations as it is contradictory in its results—and try instead to proceed on the path of the philosophical proposal of an “ontology of actuality,” the newly recovered actuality of the monument according to the features I mentioned and others one may further point out, appears to be linked to the process that from Nietzsche and Heidegger we have learned to recognize as the dissolution of metaphysics. The need for a unitary “foundation” that metaphysics attempted to answer is still there, but now it can only come to expression as the need to render compatible with one another the different “senses” of reality that are being offered by the different perspectives in science and technology. Ontology is the task of thinking insofar as it strives to recover a synthesis, if only rhetorical, persuasive, edifying, among the multiple senses of reality revealing themselves in the different language games of science. Such an ontology is knowledge of “the sense of Being”: first and foremost, perhaps only, of the meaning that the word *being* retains—as yet—in the fragmentation of reality produced by techno-science. Moreover, it can only be ontology of actuality, for just as the multiple layers of reality can no longer be reduced to the oneness of a sole first principle, so the possibility has also vanished to think of Being as a stable structure (which could only be *one*, beyond the mobile manifold of appearances). If some knowledge of the sense of Being is possible, it shall be knowledge of the sense that Being takes on in its different occurrences, in its eventual occurring.

Philosophy as an ontology of actuality speaks of our age—it *dares* to speak of our age: not a disproportionate ambition, at least not when compared to metaphysics, which purported to speak of nothing less than eternal Being, or of the conditions of

possibility of experience as such. As it sees it as the age of the end of metaphysics, it also places the newly found actuality of monument within this necessarily approximate, undefined framework. From the ontological point of view, the rediscovery of monument is a facet of the occurrence of Being and truth in the age of the dissolution of metaphysics. It is always the case that when actuality is ontologically “interpreted,” one ends up being tautological; yet, while being recognized, the sense of what is happening is also distorted, not simply repeated. To recognize the rediscovery of the monument, which following our hypothesis is taking place in our age as a facet of the occurrence of Being and truth in it, should help us to arrange the various possible elements, standards, and grounds, in a less confusing fashion.

We have become newly and especially sensitive to monumentality not just, or not mainly, because we live in a society where the acceleration of productive processes increasingly creates new “monuments”; nor simply because this very acceleration and the corresponding “mediatization” of experience seem to threaten our capacity to remember, which then reacts by demanding more and more memory; nor because acceleration and mediatization jointly strengthen our need for recognition and identity, and therefore for legitimation *via* monuments; the list could continue. All those features of the “new monumentality” are certainly highly visible, but they must be traced back to their source, they must be interpreted in the light of the comprehensive process of *ungrounding* that characterizes the event of Being in the age of the dissolution of metaphysics.

In this age truth and Being no longer grant themselves as stable objective grounds but rather as historical events, destinal openings, monuments. The character of stability that metaphysical thinking predicated of authentic Being, and on which the ever-changing manifold of appearances and becoming was supposed to rest, has revealed itself, better still has *given* itself as, or proved itself to be, the quality of the objects posited and verified by techno-science. It is not just that, as Heidegger claims (although all too often his thought is reduced to this claim), metaphysics has accomplished itself in the world of techno-scientific objectivity because science has forgotten Being. Rather, insofar as the features of metaphysics’ authentic Being have all been transferred, in fact and not simply in theory, to objects, Being is no longer what it has been

in the age of metaphysics; it can no longer grant itself as stability of verified presence. Today Being does not unveil itself as something that was already so—present, that is—only, forgotten. It occurs instead as an opening event, as the epoch-making clearing within which only beings appear so-and-so qualified: in modernity, as the objects of techno-science. Under these conditions, thinking (in the sense of attaining truth) no longer means reaching the ground, and deductively tracing the whole system of beings back to it; it means regressing to the opening events that constitute Being through their mutual enchainment, in that they define the specific opening within which beings appear and come to be. To be sure, I am speaking of events in the plural, not of the event: to place beings in the one specific opening in which they come to be (for example, the horizon of modern metaphysics) would still amount to conceiving the opening as a structural a priori, as the stable Being of the metaphysical tradition. The eventuality of the opening is authentically thought only to the extent to which it is thought within the framework of *Ge-Schick*, in Heidegger's terms: in the perspective, that is, of the togetherness (*Ge-*) of the sending (*Schick*, *Schickungen*). Such togetherness, however, never grants itself to thought in the simultaneity of full presence that is the mark of metaphysical ground. That is why in the later works, as the implications of the eventuality of Being become increasingly clear to him, Heidegger speaks of thinking (*Denken*) as of a kind of "remembrance" (*Andenken*). Such remembrance does not aim at returning to presence what is forgotten; Being cannot be given as present to re-presentation. *Andenken* as reminiscent regress does not "ground" Being by relating it to a ground that is ultimate and secure. Quite the opposite, it "ungrounds" it by placing it against a background that is never fully given; it poses it in its truth, in that it exhibits it in (its) true being, which is the eventuality, the non-necessity, the contingency of sheer occurrence.

That is a preliminary sense in which, I believe, one might say that from the perspective of an Heideggerian ontology of actuality, both truth and Being grant themselves today not as ground but as monument. Monument, moreover, here finds its definition as not simply an external but a philosophically pregnant one. Monument is the event marking and remembering the opening of Being within which a given historical existence takes place. But then the question arises: How to think the opening event in its contingency, namely how to think the opening event not as ultimate

foundation but rather within *Ge-Schick*, that is, within the framework of the whole collection of *Schickungen*? The question is crucial, for it qualifies our rediscovery of monumentality in an essential way, in such a way, that is, that while from a certain perspective monument seems to appear in its true essence as truth-as-opening, from another it becomes altogether impossible.

3. The age of world views

The access to this essential side of the issue is offered by another Heideggerian motif, one whose development in Heidegger's thought closely parallels the elaboration of his postmetaphysical ontology and of the conception of thinking as remembrance. I am referring to the recovery and reevaluation of the notion of space: while in Heidegger's main work, *Being and Time* (1927), space appeared entirely subordinate to time, that is, to temporality seen as the constitutive feature of existence and of Being itself, in the later works space is acknowledged a significance of its own. One might also say that the evolution in Heidegger's thought could be described by changing the title of *Being and Time* to *Being and Space*. Heidegger expressly speaks of a recovery of the spatial dimension, to be regarded at least as primordial as temporality, in a lecture of 1964 devoted to "art and space" (*Die Kunst und der Raum*). There it becomes apparent that the significance of the spatial dimension of *Dasein* and of Being so increases as the realization increases that Being is not ground but background and, also, ungrounding. Through the recovery of spatiality, Heidegger fulfills one of the more significant implications of thinking as remembrance. Indeed, remembrance differs from metaphysical founding in that it does not purport to reach the first principle and acquiesce in the contemplation of it. Its aim is not to conceive and grasp it (*con-cipere*, *be-greifen*), and through it to seize with a firm grip all dependent beings. Thinking as remembrance does not model itself after the *telos* of an experience of full and secure appropriation, and operates instead by placing beings against broader and broader backgrounds, through a process of unending regress: its model is rather the simultaneous coexistence in space and not the distention and concentration in moments of time. My claim, in other words, is that for Heidegger the recovery of the centrality of the spatial dimension corresponds to the becoming clear of thinking-as-remembrance, characterized as a

nonfoundational stance of thought. To be sure, Hegel's phenomenology of spirit is also a process of remembering; one, however, geared to appropriation: its end is a kind of self-transparency whose character cannot be but the punctuality of Cartesian evidence. In order to avoid that risk remembrance must let itself be guided by a "metaphor" of space rather than of time.

In *Die Kunst und der Raum* Heidegger deals with sculpture. This is, in itself, a meaningful shift from his former aesthetic reflections, which were all modeled after poetry. (One need only think of his essays on Friedrich Hölderlin and the poets, and also of that on "The Origin of the Work of Art" of 1936, published in *Holzwege*; here, beside architecture and painting, typified by the Greek temple and the well-known painting of Van Gogh's shoes, it was ultimately *Dichtung*, poetry in the specific sense of art of the word, that embodied the very essence of art. It is interesting to note that the rediscovery of the central importance of space corresponds, in Heidegger's thought, to the increasing identification of *Denken* with *Andenken*, remembrance. After all, sculpture and architecture are the arts that have always been related to the monumentality and to the remembrance of the dead.) What Heidegger says in the lecture of 1964 might hold true also, indeed to a greater extent, for architecture and urban design. It is a step, however, that has only been taken by Heideggerian hermeneutics: the central place occupied by architecture in the "aesthetics" of Hans-Georg Gadamer's *Truth and Method* could hardly be understood in the absence of an explicit connection with these aspects of Heidegger's late philosophy (in fact, I would even venture to claim that this is one of the reasons why Gadamer's theory of architecture has so far commanded little or no attention, unlike other parts of his work).

The reference to the spatial metaphor frees the identification thinking-remembrance from any possible Hegelian misunderstanding. Here, thinking does not mean appropriating the truth of the process by comprehending it in its wholeness and in its connections, in a way that remains ultimately foundational (such has always been, after all, the aim of metaphysical philosophies of history). Rather, it means placing oneself, and things, into truth conceived of as the horizon that sustains them, and us, through its very irreducible and networklike multiplicity of references; such a network one does not appropriate, one rather belongs to it in the mode of a

correspondence by entering a never-ending dialogue, whose peculiar sense lies in its being carried on through "attuned" questions and answers.

Once we transfer all of this to the level of our reflections on monument, we see that the event marking the opening of the concrete historical existence of ages, societies, groups, expressly gives itself as monument only within the horizon of a multiplicity that is recognized and thematically acknowledged as such. Monument's truth—in both senses of the genitive: the authentic meaning of monument and truth-as-monument—only grants itself when monument unequivocally ceases to be associated with foundation. As long as foundational thought holds out, as long as metaphysics lasts (that is, as long as the modern ideal of "central" rationality, be it historicist or paleopositivist, holds out), monument is merely a metaphor for foundation, an allegory of it, and vanishes as soon as thought relates to the proper meaning; it is then, perhaps, only a rhetorical ornament, a way of conveying an everlasting truth concerning existence and values, which it provides with an "aesthetic" coating. Within that horizon, only those monuments really last that survive such translation into their "proper" meaning, such demythologizing, one might say. Foundational thought characteristically opposes rhetoric, embellishments, and ornament in general, which are tolerated only to the extent that they support and corroborate the true meaning and function; only, that is, to the extent that they are "grounded." Here, too, when it comes to the issue of the relationship between essence and ornament, it is the postmetaphysical mentality to do justice to monument, to take it seriously, as it were. In fact, a constitutive ornamental character is always embedded in monument: to celebrate a victory, to solemnize the figure of a national hero or a monarch, to mark a decisive date in the life of a community, these are all cases where something is deliberately dignified by means of signs that are ornamental in kind. By definition, ornament is a sign that cannot stand critical scrutiny, in a foundational perspective; one that is, that thinks of truth as correspondence to true structures. The dissolution of metaphysical, foundational thought is thus at the same time the freeing of ornament (on this issue, see my *The End of Modernity* [Cambridge: Polity Press, 1988], chap. 5).

That ornament be freed is only possible within a situation in which the groundlessness of existence has revealed itself as its true ontological attribute.

Otherwise put, the relation to Being that constitutes existence is not grounded on solid and objective foundations; but rather, being groundless and ungrounded, it is only sustained by its relationship to its background (whereby it is meant the network of the manifold world-opening events, those that give its relation to the world the character of a possibility). Under these circumstances, the monument is "recovered," also in the literal sense, as an object that is given in space (this point would deserve further treatment: Does the transformation of our attitude to temporality, shall we call it the "end of history," also affect our attitude toward the space we live and inhabit?). The spatiality of monument, looked at from Heidegger's viewpoint, also means its irreducible multiplicity. It is the simultaneity in which the *Schickungen*, the historical-destinal openings that constitute (the history of) Being, grant themselves in the age of the end of metaphysics. On this issue, even against the letter of his text, Heidegger's proximity to Nietzsche must be acknowledged. The age of world views—it is the title of one of the essays in *Holzwege*—is the age described by Nietzsche in the second of his "untimely meditations," *On the Uses and Disadvantages of History for Life* (1874). Modern, or rather late modern man is pictured as a tourist wandering in the garden of history, where he visits the symbolic forms of the past as the sections of a museum; he is also viewed as someone who searches the past as one would search the wardrobe of a theater, where masks and costumes may be put on and taken off at will, according to the kind of "ornament" one momentarily needs. To be sure, in that essay Nietzsche described that condition as the culmination of decadence and loss of artistic spontaneity (the acute awareness that all is historical and ephemeral leaves man no capacity to create); in the subsequent course of his thought, however, beginning with *Human, All-Too-Human* (1878), Nietzsche shall develop the conviction that the *Übermensch* is identical with the man of the masks, once the decision for the eternal return has freed him from all teleological delusions and violent metaphysical expectations. Now, what I am here suggesting is a move, I must say, not explicitly authorized by either Nietzsche or Heidegger's texts: namely, to see Heidegger's thinking-as-remembrance as a *Verwindung*, that is, as both a recovery (in the various meanings of the term) and a distortion, of the attitude of modern man described by Nietzsche in the second untimely meditation. In such "distorting

recovery" a transformation takes place that is something of a convalescence: modern man recovers from his longing for an ultimate foundation and acknowledges Being's vocation to dissolve, which becomes apparent in the dissolution of notions such as permanence, stability, metaphysical eternity—which are now rightly associated with the objects of techno-scientific reckoning and manipulation posited by the will-to-power.

To summarize, I am asking if the theatrical masks among which modern man wanders, the historical-destinal openings that explicitly grant themselves in their contingency as the "human, all-too-human" values spoken of by Nietzsche, and in fact are the only values that constitute Being, can still be called monuments. The question is legitimate, since to the essence of monument belongs the illusion of uniqueness and eternity, and ultimately the ambition to be a monument of foundation. Here it perhaps becomes clear that our age frees the essence of monument by freeing ornament, that is, by showing the ontologically ungrounded character of existence and, therefore, the ontological weight of the (historical) opening event; while by the same token it also appears to foreclose the possibility of further monumentality. The question of the monument is an aspect, or perhaps a metaphor, a cipher, of the question Nietzsche was addressing by his thought of the *Übermensch*, the same that Heidegger takes up in his search for a new beginning of thought, beyond metaphysics and its end. The problem is whether history can give itself only as the illusion to establish the sole and necessary ground of Being, or also as the lucid recognition of the eventuality of Being. The reduction of monuments to masks, or even to sheer signs and documents referring to life-forms that raise no claim to the status of metaphysically grounded models, should not be regarded as a symptom of the "moral crisis," namely, of the decadence of our society. On the contrary, it is an essentially positive stage toward the new possible monumentality: this will very likely require us to reconsider first and foremost the relationship between monument and trace, that is, between the symbol of foundation and the sheer mark in space. The drastic reduction operated by the structuralist mind on the contents of a few culture-founding dichotomies (regarding food, sexual relations, language) is a good case in point: there is culture where there are orders, oppositions, differences, irrespective of their contents, which are largely accidental and irrelevant. The limit of

structuralism was that it considered that formalistic reduction as the genuine truth of human civilization, as the description that could finally demythologize it; whereas it has probably been simply one moment in the history of the dissolution of metaphysics, and as such it cannot be considered the unveiling of the truth of a stable structure.

4. Monument, anamnesis, and social rhetoric

It is certainly not up to philosophy to indicate the way out of the current contradictory predicament, wherein to the increased need for monuments seems to correspond the impossibility to build new ones. Philosophy can nonetheless try to elaborate the sense of the analogy between its own predicament in the age of the end of metaphysics, implying the dissolution of foundations (is it mere chance that the term evokes the experience of building?), and that of contemporary architecture. The path that postmetaphysical thinking has taken in order to continue to think even when it can no longer think in foundational terms, is perhaps not too far from the one that architecture may follow in order to answer the new, sharper need for monumentality. The masters of postmetaphysical thinking, Nietzsche and Heidegger, have shown to the philosophy of our age the path of anamnesis. Once the belief in eternal truths and first principles no longer has currency, the only kind of "rational" argument left is the one that appeals to shared experiences and memories. When Nietzsche writes that "God is dead," he is not making a metaphysical profession of atheism, he is not claiming that God does not exist. On the contrary, Nietzsche is evoking those that he regards as the shared experiences of modern European man (from the social and political transformations of modernity to the encounter with "other" cultures that have become accessible through the widening of historical and anthropological knowledge); insofar as he made those experiences, modern man is supposed no longer capable, as it were, of believing in the God of metaphysics.

Late modern monument, like Heidegger's act of thinking, cannot help but be anamnestic. To be sure, that sounds like a tautology, since monument is by definition an object that is aiming to become a trace for memory: a trace, that is, which is *aere perennius*, longer enduring than bronze. The matter is, however, that in postmodern culture nothing seems worth remembering and "perpetuating" except just what is

being remembered, and only insofar as it is being remembered. On atemporal grounds it is impossible to decide what deserves to be perpetuated. Monument, perhaps not unlike the trace of writing for Jacques Derrida, is always already based on a "former" monumentality; it does not remember an event, a person, or a value, but only a memory, which it turns into monument insofar as it is a memory actually shared by a community that recognizes itself in it. This means that as it happens with philosophy, for architecture as well the dissolution of foundation demands that the reference to the community be intensified. Even in today's hard sciences the truth or validity of a statement is increasingly, almost exclusively, verified by the consensus reached among the community of scientists, of "experts." The monuments of "metaphysical" ages were built on the basis of choices that were regarded as legitimate because they appealed to values that were evidently held by everybody (religion, country, and the like), and because they proceeded from the authoritative decision of a sovereign who was felt to be the legitimate representative of such values. In late modern societies, which are de facto pluralistic and, generally speaking, de jure democratic, there is no such thing as everybody's values nor the legitimate sovereignty of an individual subject. Two possibilities are thus open to what we have indicated as new monumentality: it might turn to a renewed romantic aesthetics of genius, according to which the architect, simply by virtue of his being an artist, should be able to grasp and indicate those values worth "monumentalizing." This is not the same as producing a work of art: poets, writers, and painters do not produce "monuments." Or, if it does not wish to do so, as I believe it shouldn't, the new monumentality needs a much more intense reference to social rhetoric than in the past. To be sure, a certain measure of "genius" is admitted, even required here. Even the most faithful rendering of the community's shared values must always ultimately be filtered and interpreted by an individual artistic personality that brings in its own peculiar sensitivity and its own original creativity. It remains true, however, that the problematic character of postmodern monument bears also, perhaps mainly, upon the broader issue of the project's legitimation, no longer conceivable as appealing to either "naturally" shared values (indisputable because accepted by everybody) or to the sovereign's will (legitimate and legitimizing). In very trivial terms this is the question we are asking: What

becomes of the architect's practice, especially when it comes to monuments, within a society in which the architect must negotiate, in most cases, with clients such as the democratically elected public administrations, which as such cannot be the adequate—that is, reliable, legitimate—subjects of decisions concerning matters of taste, let alone of moral choices (given the “polytheistic” moral attitude of our societies)?

To raise the question obviously does not mean to know the answer, nor, more importantly, does it mean to presume to have exhausted the meaning of the issue of monument. Something is perhaps gained, however, if the question can move the meditation on monument toward an outcome that is capable of affecting the conception and the practice of architecture. Just like philosophers, today's architects shall have to accept to conceive of their own function less as creators than as interpreters.